OPEN LETTER · EYE ON SHOALHAVEN COUNCIL

Stephen Prothero asks Shoalhaven Councillors to justify their committees' value

Sent 8 April 2026 · To Cr Tribe, Cr Boyd, Cr Norris, Cr Krikstolaitis, Cr Killian, Cr Casmiri, Cr Proudfoot, Cr Wilkins, Cr Dunn · Response requested by 29 April 2026

Open Letter to Shoalhaven Councillors

Dear Councillors,

I am writing to ask each of you to take a hard look at the committees you sit on and ask a very simple question: are they actually delivering anything of real value?

This is not a criticism of the idea of oversight.

Committees can serve a useful purpose when they test proposals, sharpen priorities, identify risks early, and help Council make better decisions. But that is not the same as meeting, receiving reports, listening to presentations, and leaving "informed" while very little changes on the ground.

Too often, that is how some of these committees now appear.

- **Staff prepare reports.**
- **Governance staff organise agendas and minutes.**
- **Senior officers attend.**
- **Councillors spend time in meetings.**
- **Venues, livestreaming and administration all carry a cost.**

None of that is free. Every hour spent servicing a low-value committee is an hour not spent on work that residents actually need done.

That is the issue.

If a committee is genuinely productive, then it should be able to show it. It should be able to point to clear outcomes, changed priorities, improved decisions, risks avoided, delays reduced, or real projects advanced. If it cannot do that, then councillors should be honest enough to say so.

No one expects perfection. But ratepayers are entitled to expect that committees do more than create the appearance of activity.

So I ask each of you to review the committees you sit on and answer a few basic questions.

1. **What has this committee tangibly delivered in the last six to twelve months?**
2. **What decisions or improvements would not have happened without it?**
3. **What staff time does it consume?**

4. **Is the value greater than the cost?**

Could the same information be provided in a simpler, cheaper and less staff-intensive way?

If the answer is that a committee is not adding real value, then please say so publicly.

- **Do not sit silently while officer time is burned just to maintain process for process's sake.**
- **Do not accept a culture where being briefed is mistaken for governing.**
- **And do not leave staff tied up servicing structures that may no longer justify themselves.**
- **If a committee is useful, make it sharper, clearer and more outcome-focused.**
- **If it is not useful, reform it or remove it.**

That is not anti-governance. It is good governance.

Shoalhaven Council has serious pressures: roads, infrastructure backlogs, financial constraints, housing, planning, community trust. In that environment, every piece of councillor time and every hour of staff effort should matter. Committees should help solve problems, not become one more layer of overhead.

So this is a straightforward request: evaluate the committees honestly, speak out where they are wasting time, and either turn them into something productive or free staff up to do real work.

Ratepayers are not paying for the theatre of oversight.

They are paying for results.

Yours sincerely,

Stephen Prothero
